Muhammad Hakim, and thus the last viable threat to Akbar's throne, but also historically, in that it began the final decade of the first Islamic millennium, and astrologically, in that it witnessed a rare conjunction of Saturn and Jupiter – a conjunction, or *qiran*, that was itself a millennial event and had last occurred at about the time of the beginning of Islam.
Such rare conjunctions of planets had long been used by conquerors and emperors to mark their own reigns as equally unique, even world-changing. Timur, for example, had titled himself Sahib Qiran, Lord of the Conjunction, as would Akbar's grandson, Shahjahan. Akbar, characteristically, went a step ahead of both.

Just as Akbar celebrated Mirza Hakim's defeat with Nauroz, he celebrated the qiran, notes Azfar Moin, by issuing a new coin stamped with the word '*alfi*' ('millennium') and commissioning a new history, *Tarikh-i-Alfi*, of the past 1000 years. It is significant that this history begins with the death of the Prophet Muhammad, not his birth, which would have been the more conventional and appropriate choice. Instead, by beginning 'with the end of a sacred being, an embodied absence', Moin argues that the history 'set up an expectation of a new beginning and a new being, i.e., a new cycle of time'.[49]

This new beginning is, in fact, the book's punchline: it '[ends] with the reign of Akbar, [so] one can surmise that it was the Mughal emperor who had filled this absence and fulfilled this expectation by inaugurating the new millennium'. For anyone who missed the hint, the *tarikh*'s authors also declared Akbar 'the Renewer of the Second Millennium (*Mujaddid-i Alf-i Thani*)'.[50]

Mujaddid, Mujtahid, Mahdi; a brahmachari reborn, Vishnu's avatar, Chagatai Chakravartin: it followed that an emperor of such destiny – prophesied and political – should have a special category of men in his service; not subjects, not mansabdars, but disciples.

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'And they sacrificed their wealth, and life, reputation, and religion,' Badauni sighs, 'to their friendship for the Emperor.' These were the four pledges made by new recruits to what is popularly known as Akbar's *din-i-ilahi*, his 'divine faith'. Having made their vows, the faithful would bow